down and there was to be no arguing.

So here we are, I said. The ultimate nightmare. The worst of all worst-case scenarios. Any bad actor in the world would now be able to find us, and it would just be me with a pistol to stop them.

Oh wait. No pistol. I'm in Canada.

I rang Pa. He wouldn't take my calls.

Just then I got a text from Willy. *Can you speak?*

Great. I was sure my older brother, after our recent walk in the Sandringham gardens, would be sympathetic. That he'd step up.

He said it was a government decision. Nothing to be done.

78.

LOYDE WAS PLEADING with his superiors at home, trying to get them at least to postpone the date when he and his team pulled out. He showed me the emails. He wrote: *We can't just…leave them here!*

The person at the other end wrote: *The decision has been made. As of March 31 they're by themselves.*

I scrambled to find new security. I spoke to consultants, gathered estimates. I filled a notebook with research. The Palace directed me to a firm, which quoted me a price. Six million a year.

I slowly hung up.

In the midst of all this darkness came the horrible news that my old friend Caroline Flack had taken her life. She couldn't stand it anymore, apparently. The relentless abuse at the hands of the press, year after year, had finally broken her. I felt so awful for her family. I remembered how they'd all suffered for her mortal sin of going out with me.

She'd been so light and funny that night we met. The definition of carefree.

It would've been impossible then to imagine this outcome.

I told myself it was an important reminder. I wasn't being overdramatic, I wasn't warning about things that would never happen. What Meg and I were dealing with was indeed a question of life and death.